



Soaring high: Parul Chaudhary set a national record — 9:12.46 — in 3000m steeplechase. **Right:** Shaili Singh secured bronze in long jump.

Medal tally

China - 32
19 gold, 9 silver, 4 bronze

India - 24
8 gold, 10 silver, 6 bronze

Japan - 28
5 gold, 11 silver, 12 bronze



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Later that evening, 23-year-old middle-distance runner Pooja ran the seventh-fastest time by an Indian woman in the 800m, clocking 2:01.89 to take bronze.

The previous day, however, would see another Pooja deliver one of the all-time great performances by a young Indian athlete.

Although she was taking part in her second Asian Athletics Championships, this was her first as a senior (she had previously competed as a 16-year-old at the 2023 edition in Bangkok).

At least on paper, she shouldn't have stood a chance. Having turned 18 just a few weeks ago, Pooja was the second youngest in the women's high jump in Gumi. Five other competitors, including an Olympic finalist, had jumped higher than her in their careers.

Pooja, however, defied the odds, setting two personal bests — 1.86m and 1.89m — to stun a strong field. The result not only crowned her as the youngest Asian champion from India, but also opened the door to the World Championships in Japan later this year, where — as the



continental titleholder — she holds a provisional qualification.

It remains to be seen whether the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) will submit her entry for the Worlds. Speaking to reporters after the tournament, AFI president Adille Sumariwalla didn't announce any change to the federation's policy of allowing only athletes who meet the World Championships' automatic qualification standard to compete in Japan.

"We want some athletes to be preparing for the big competitions of next year like the Asian Games," he said in response to a question from *Sportstar*.

At 1.97m, the qualification standard in the women's high jump might prove a leap too far for Pooja. However, some athletes — if their performances at the Asian Championships are any indication — could well meet the World standards too.

Parul Chaudhary won twin silvers in the women's 5000m and 3000m steeplechase, but it was her national record in the latter (9:12.46) that will have followers of Indian athletics